

Indian shooting's golden boy destined for bigger targets

After clinching a **National Games gold** in men's 10m air pistol, India's latest shooting prodigy Jonathan Gavin Antony juggles animated series, board exams, and shooting trials.

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Late last month in Dehradun, after qualifying for his first-ever shooting final at the National Games, Jonathan Gavin Antony decided it was time to unwind, just the way most 15-year-olds would — indulging in a marathon animated feature session, watching *Naruto*, *Teen Titans Go*, and *Oggy and the Cockroaches*.

Indian shooting is no stranger to prodigies like him.

In fact, Jonathan secured his place in the final eight by edging past Saurabh Chaudhary, the Asian Games champion, Tokyo Olympian and multiple-time World Cup winner who was once regarded as a prodigy himself.

Both had shot a score of 578, one point higher than the qualifying mark for the previous year's Olympics, with the same number of inner 10s. However, Jonathan progressed based on a superior final series.

Reaching the final of a senior national competition just two years after first picking up a pistol is an achievement in itself, but Jonathan went even further.

Showing no signs of fatigue, he delivered a near-flawless performance in the final, defeating a field that included Olympic bronze medallist Sarabjot Singh to claim his first senior national gold medal.

He hadn't started the final particularly well, shooting a 9.1 with his first attempt. He admitted to feeling a bit nervous. "I saw all these senior players next to me. I was actually looking to see what they were doing, and in that moment, I shot my first shot badly. But after that, I started focusing on myself," Jonathan said.

With just three shots remaining, he had established a commanding 2.4-point lead over the rest of the field.

Early gains: Jonathan delivered a near-flawless performance, defeating a field that included Olympic bronze medallist Sarabjot Singh to claim his first senior national gold medal.

RITU RAJ KONWAR



Jonathan is a freestyle shooter, similar to Yusuf Dikec, the viral gold-medal-winning Turkish champion from the 2024 Olympics.